

BONUS RESOURCE

50+ Copilot Prompts for Word

Ready-to-paste prompts to draft, summarise and polish documents in seconds

- 50+ prompts organised by what you are actually doing: drafting, rewriting, summarising, polishing
- How to ground a draft in your own files instead of getting generic output
- The Rewrite and Visualize-as-table tools, and when to reach for each
- A five-minute pre-send pass and a troubleshooting page

Current as of September 2026. Assumes Microsoft 365 Copilot in Word on the web or desktop, and a Microsoft 365 Copilot licence.

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1 Set up before you draft

Two minutes that decide whether the output is generic or genuinely useful

Copilot in Word does four jobs: create a draft, refine existing text, comprehend a document, and help you collaborate on it. Two minutes of setup determines whether the first one gives you something usable or something generic.

Check	What to do and why it matters
Licence	Requires a Microsoft 365 Copilot licence. Without it, the Draft and Rewrite entry points will not appear.
Open Copilot correctly	The Copilot button in the corner of the document opens the chat pane in Edit mode. A blank document or a new line also surfaces Draft with Copilot directly in the canvas.
Reference your own files	The Reference a file option (or typing / followed by a file name) grounds a draft in up to three of your existing documents, rather than producing generic content. This is the single biggest quality lever in this whole pack.
Know the difference: Draft vs Rewrite	Draft with Copilot creates new content from a description. Rewrite works on text you have already selected. Using the wrong one is the most common source of a frustrating result.
Coaching, where available	Some licences include a Coaching preview that reviews a draft before you move on. Worth switching on if you see it - it catches what the rewrite prompts in section 4 are built to fix.

The single highest-leverage habit in this pack: reference a file before you draft. "Write an intro for our Q3 report" from nothing is generic. The same prompt grounded in last quarter's report and this quarter's data pulls in your organisation's actual language, numbers and prior decisions.

2 Starting from a blank page

Draft with Copilot, in the canvas of a new document or a new line

For a new document or a new line, Draft with Copilot appears directly in the canvas. Give it a description - a sentence is enough to start, but the more shape you give it, the less editing you do after.

"Write a one-page project proposal for [project], covering the problem, the proposed approach, timeline and what I need approved."

"Draft a business case for [initiative], including the current cost of not doing it and the expected outcome if we do."

"Write an executive summary for [topic] in three paragraphs: context, findings, recommendation."

"Draft a policy document for [topic], covering purpose, scope, the policy itself, and who it applies to."

"Write a cover letter for [role] at [company], drawing on [background/resume] for relevant experience."

"Draft meeting minutes template with sections for attendees, decisions, action items and next steps."

"Write a client-facing project update: what shipped, what is in progress, and what we need from them."

"Draft a two-paragraph announcement about [change], written for people who will be affected by it but were not involved in deciding it."

In a document that already has some content, use Inspire Me instead of a fresh Draft prompt - it continues in the voice and direction you have already established, rather than starting a new one.

3 Drafting from your own files

The single biggest quality lever in this pack

This is where Copilot in Word stops being a generic writer and starts being useful. Reference a file and describe what you want pulled from it and how you want it shaped.

"Using [previous report], draft this quarter's version with the same structure, updated for [new data or changes]."

"Draft a proposal using [prior proposal] as a template, adapted for [new client/project]."

"Summarise the key points from [document A] and [document B] into a single briefing document that reconciles where they agree and flags where they differ."

"Using [meeting notes], draft a formal decision memo covering what was decided, why, and who is accountable for what."

"Draft an onboarding guide using [existing process document], simplified for someone with no prior context."

"Using [contract or policy], draft a plain-language summary a non-lawyer could actually follow."

Referencing a file only grounds Copilot in the files you explicitly select - not your wider organisational data. If a draft is missing context you expected it to have, check whether the relevant document was actually referenced.

4 Rewrite: fixing what is already there

Select the text first - Rewrite and Draft are different tools

Select the text first, then use Rewrite - this is a different tool from Draft, and asking Draft to "fix this paragraph" with nothing selected is a common source of disappointment. Rewrite offers several versions; step through them rather than accepting the first.

"Make this more concise without losing the key numbers."

"Rewrite this so the main point is in the first sentence, not the last."

"This paragraph buries the ask. Rewrite it so the request is unmistakable."

"Simplify this for a reader with no background in [topic]."

"Rewrite this to sound more confident, without overstating what we actually know."

"This section repeats itself. Tighten it so each point appears once."

"Rewrite this paragraph as three bullet points that keep all the same information."

"Make this sound less like a form letter and more like a person wrote it."

Regenerate rather than settle. If the first rewrite is close but not right, Regenerate for another pass, or add a follow-up instruction in the compose box - "more direct" or "less formal" - rather than manually fixing an output that started from the wrong instinct.

5 Summarise and ask

Chat with the document you have open, with citations back to the source

The Copilot chat pane can answer questions about the document you have open, with citations back to where in the document each answer came from - useful for anything longer than you want to re-read.

"Summarise this document in five bullet points."

"What are the three main arguments in this document, and how strong is the evidence for each?"

"Does this document ever actually state [specific claim]? Quote where, or tell me it does not."

"What questions would a skeptical reader have after reading this, that the document does not yet answer?"

"Summarise only the recommendations in this document, not the background."

"Where in this document is [topic] discussed? Point me to the section."

"Does anything in this document contradict anything else in it?"

"Turn this document's conclusion into a single tweet-length sentence."

6 Tables, lists and structure

Select, then Visualize as a table - fine-tune with a follow-up instruction

Select a block of text, then choose Visualize as a table from the same inline Copilot menu Rewrite lives in. Fine-tune the result with a follow-up instruction rather than rebuilding it by hand.

"Turn this into a table with columns for [criteria], one row per [item]."

"Convert this list into a table with a bold header row and an empty status column."

"Restructure this document with clear headings and subheadings based on its existing content."

"Turn this paragraph of requirements into a numbered checklist."

"This table is hard to scan. Add a column showing the difference between the first and last columns."

"Convert this table into a plain-language paragraph summary for someone who will not open the spreadsheet."

7 Tone, length and audience

The same content, reshaped for who is actually reading it

The same content, reshaped for who is actually going to read it. Use these as follow-up instructions on a draft or rewrite you already have, not as a first prompt from nothing.

"Make this sound appropriate for a board audience: less detail, more implication for the business."

"Rewrite this for a technical audience who will want the specifics this version glosses over."

"Shorten this to half its current length without dropping the recommendation."

"Lengthen this section with more supporting detail from [file], keeping the same structure."

"Make this warmer and more personal - it currently reads like a form letter."

"Make this more formal - it currently reads too casually for an external audience."

"Translate the tone of this into something appropriate for a first-time reader with no context on the project."

8 Polish before you send

Five minutes that catch what the draft still gets wrong

Five minutes before anything goes out. This is not about generating more text - it is about catching what the draft still gets wrong.

"Check this document for anything that sounds overconfident given the evidence actually presented."

"Read this as the recipient would. What would their first question be?"

"Find every instance of jargon in this document that a first-time reader would not know."

"Does this document ever ask for something specific, or does it stay vague throughout? Point out where it should be more direct."

"Check for consistency: does this document use the same terms for the same things throughout, or does the language drift?"

"What is the single weakest sentence in this document, and how would you fix it?"

Run the "read as the recipient" prompt on anything going to someone outside your team. It catches assumed context and unstated jargon far more reliably than reading your own writing back.

9

When it does not work

Symptoms, causes and fixes

Where Copilot in Word commonly disappoints, and what is usually behind it.

Symptom	Almost always the cause
Draft is generic and could be about anything	No file was referenced. Ground the prompt in an existing document with Reference a file before drafting.
Rewrite button does not appear	Text was not selected first. Rewrite works on a highlighted selection, not the document as a whole.
Referenced file's content is missing from the draft	Only the files explicitly selected are used, not your wider organisational data. Confirm the right file was actually attached to the prompt.
Summary misses something you know is in the document	Very long documents may summarise the most prominent sections rather than every one. Ask about the specific section by name.
Table conversion looks wrong	The source text was ambiguous about what the columns should be. State the columns explicitly rather than letting Copilot infer them.
Tone keeps drifting back to generic corporate voice	Add a concrete tone instruction each time - "like a person, not a form letter" - rather than expecting one early instruction to hold for the whole document.

QUICK REFERENCE

50+ Copilot Prompts for Word

STARTING FRESH

- Write a [document type] for [purpose], covering [sections]
- Reference [file] and draft using the same structure, updated for [changes]
- In an existing doc: use Inspire Me to continue in the established voice

FIXING WHAT IS THERE

- Select text first, then Rewrite - never Draft on existing content
- Make this more concise / more confident / simpler for [audience]
- Regenerate rather than settle for a rewrite that is close but not right

UNDERSTANDING A DOCUMENT

- Summarise this in five bullet points
- What are the main arguments, and how strong is the evidence for each?
- Does this ever actually state [claim]? Quote where, or say it does not

BEFORE YOU SEND

- Read this as the recipient would - what is their first question?
- Find jargon a first-time reader would not know
- What is the single weakest sentence, and how would you fix it?

Copilot in Word removes the blank-page problem and the read-it-again-to-be-sure problem. Neither of those was ever the hard part of writing - deciding what to say was. Spend the time you get back there.